

format were tweaked to cater to a television audience reaped massive benefits for the league. It eventually became the second-most watched sporting league in the country, after the IPL.

Chaudhari, donning the yellow of the Telugu Titans, became a household name and eventually the league's poster boy. It helped that the raider carried oodles of spunk and an almost arrogant confidence, often taking difficult games by the neck and turning them in his team's favour. His imperious performances earned him the title of 'Showman' — he was the league's first superstar.

"For me, the PKL trophy was the one jewel missing from a crown that had everything else. Despite the Asian Games medal, World Cup medal, and national titles, I would get asked, 'PKL kabhi jeete?' (Have you won PKL?) All my achievements aside, it was the one trophy I didn't have that stood out."

Years past his prime in the PKL, when raiding opportunities were few



RAHUL CHAUDHARI BECAME A HOUSEHOLD NAME AND EVENTUALLY THE LEAGUE'S POSTER BOY. HIS IMPERIOUS PERFORMANCES EARNED HIM THE TITLE OF 'SHOWMAN'



and far between, Chaudhari — now in the Jaipur Pink Panthers' colours — finally won the PKL trophy in 2022. Team owner Abhishek Bachchan famously proclaimed, "From season 1, he has been putting in the effort to make a name for himself, so this title is for him."

The youngster who once just wanted to play his favourite sport on TV had finally earned his flowers, at a stage in his career when the league's

